Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art and Design

Programme Specification

1. General Information

Programme title:	Contemporary Art Practice
Award:	Master's
Qualification Framework level:	Level 7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Arts & Humanities
Campus location(s):	Battersea
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to:	2026-27

2. Programme Philosophy

Contemporary Art Practice (CAP) at the Royal College of Art is a cutting-edge MA programme in the School of Arts & Humanities that is driven by a post-medium, critical approach to the making and reception of art, where theory and practice come together to form new ways of responding to the contemporary world. The programme supports the development of your art practice within a responsive, dialogical and critical context with an emphasis on wider political issues – interrogating art production in relation to urgent socio-political contexts as well as questioning and redefining practice.

CAP supports ambitious, exploratory and research driven artists, with programme specialisms in: critical, speculative and social art practices, moving image, performance, writing and techno-aesthetics. Our approach to Contemporary Art Practice is not determined by either technology or material, and CAP students create work using any media possible: from images, installations and moving image works, to publications and sonic art, participatory events, 3D modelling and VR, writing and performance. The programme offers a flexible environment that supports collective and peer-led learning.

The Contemporary Art Practice programme is profoundly attentive to the critical condition of our environment, humanity and the world around us and our students and graduates both contribute to and also expand the traditional roles assigned to artists to include modes of practice such as artist as activist, artist as publisher, artist as educator, artist as urban geographer and artist as community organiser. You are encouraged to situate your practice within the social, political and economic conditions of the contemporary world; identifying what art can contribute to ongoing material, critical, technological and philosophical debates.

The MA Contemporary Art Practice offers a discursive environment in which to explore contemporary issues for thinking about, making and presenting contemporary art supported by individual tutorials, group critiques, lectures, seminars and workshops that take place across the year. Each unit: Situating Contemporary Art Practice, Demonstrating Contemporary Art Practice and the Contemporary Art Practice: Independent Research Project is tailored to nurture the development of your art practice from the earliest manifestations of ideas through to platforms for exhibition and making-public, whilst also providing the skills required to be able to situate your practice within current dialogues and debates. Supported individual learning is complemented by generative workshops and collaborative events and exhibitions, with critical feedback offered throughout the degree from world-leading contemporary artists, writers and curators.

The MA Contemporary Art Practice is premised on an understanding that artists, makers, writers, curators, critics and historians today are concerned with the function, contribution and work of the artist and art's potential to reflect upon and intervene in the world. CAP lectures, reading groups, collaborations, group critiques, generative workshops and seminars interconnect with one-to-one

tutorials and technical support as well as the School and College-wide teaching units to create an innovative, dynamic and responsive learning environment for new approaches to the thinking, making and exhibition of contemporary art.

3. Educational Aims and Learning Outcomes of the Programme

Programme aims

- You will be supported in the development of contemporary artworks through critical and conceptual frameworks.
- You will be provided with a learning environment which privileges experimentation and self-reflexivity in order to develop an ambitious and critical contemporary art practice.
- We will establish a dialogue between theory and practice and support you to develop a practice which negotiates received theories, engages with the ethical dimensions of working with others and demonstrates ways of understanding, articulating and shaping the future of contemporary art.
- You will be taught how to plan and produce artworks of high quality and significance both technically and conceptually.
- We will support and develop a self-reflective and critical understanding of professional practice within contemporary art.

Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your programme-specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of contemporary art practice;
- Plan and produce work that is informed by contemporary art research and practice both independently and as a responsive member of the artistic and wider community;
- Position and develop your awareness of the core areas of your research and practice and how

this is situated within and contributes to the wider field of contemporary art practice;
- Demonstrate originality, imagination and curiosity in how you build on existing strategies in your approach to art making;
- Clearly and appropriately communicate your practice in a variety of contexts demonstrating versatility and inclusivity with an awareness of the politics of knowledge production and discourse;
- Position and evaluate your professional identity, defining your relationship to contemporary art practice.

4. What Will I Learn?

Curriculum Map

<table>
<tr><th>Term 1</th><th>Term 2</th><th>Term 3</th></tr>
<tr><td>AcrossRCA
(College Wide Unit)
(15 Credits)</td><td>Urgency of the Arts
(School Wide Unit)
(15 Credits)</td><td rowspan="3">Independent Research Project
(60 Credits)</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">Situating Contemporary Art Practice
(45 Credits)</td><td>Demonstrating Contemporary Art Practice
(30 Credits)</td></tr>
<tr><td>Core Skills
(15 Credits)</td></tr>
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Programme Structure

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
Situating Contemporary Art Practice	1	45	Core
AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)	1	15	Core
Demonstrating Contemporary Art Practice	2	30	Core
Urgency of the Arts (School-wide unit)	2	15	Core
Core Skills	2	15	Core
Independent Research Project	3	60	Core

Situating Contemporary Art Practice
This introductory unit provides the practical and theoretical foundations of the programme. A series of programme lectures, practical and generative workshops and seminars, individual tutorials and group sessions will support you in the production and experimentation of artworks, helping you to position and situate your practice within contemporary dialogues and debates.

Demonstrating Contemporary Art Practice
This unit engages with modes of making-public and with collaborative practices. You will have the opportunity to expand professional networks and engage with sites and contexts of art production and reception. You will be supported in your learning through individual and group tutorials, lectures, workshops and reading groups. You will also have the opportunity to collaborate with peers across all

aspects of planning and delivery of a series of public projects and events which may involve external partners and also deliver a presentation of your work in the form of an artist talk.

AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)
Taking place in Term 1, this unit aims to support you to meet the challenges of a complex, uncertain and changing world by bringing you together with students from across the college to work collaboratively in cross-programme interdisciplinary teams. In your team, you will develop a self-initiated themed project, informed by expertise within and beyond the College. The focus of the unit is on learning through the process of the collaborative development of an idea. Rather than aiming for a completed product, solution or concrete answer, AcrossRCA is about an openness to what is generated through experimentation, dialogue and reflexivity. What happens when we move across disciplinary borders and put the kinds of knowledge, experience and skills we each bring to the RCA into conversation with others?

Core Skills
The aim of the Core Skills unit is to support you in advancing your academic and professional skills to help you reflect upon your responsibility as a practitioner and researcher in the world. Consisting of a School-wide lecture series and in-Programme seminars and workshops, you will consider how your practice responds to questions of inclusion, diversity, equality, critically, sustainably and risk in relation to contemporary contexts of display, encounter and circulation. Taking place in Term 2, the unit will support you towards your IRP and beyond by asking you to reflect on how the ethical values of your work and research translate into methods and modes of display, engagement, presentation and address.

Independent Research Project
The 60 credit Independent Research Project (IRP) is an opportunity to build a body of work that addresses the key ambitions of your research and practice. You will work towards presenting a work or works in the IRP Public Exhibition, which enables you to explore how you can activate your work in a public context, experiment with the most appropriate forms of realising your ideas and gain critical feedback. The IRP exhibition will be followed by a period of reflection and further development, which emphasises planning for continued practice and research post-graduation.

You will produce a final artwork for presentation in a public exhibition. You will be supported through individual and group tutorials and one-to-one technical support, alongside a series of programme specific and School-wide professional practice lectures and workshops, with critical feedback on your work via an external group of arts professionals.

There are three Independent Study weeks included in your programme (one per term). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

5. How Will I Learn?

Briefings
Briefing sessions presenting key information about teaching, learning, assessment and core programme activities are presented at the start of each CAP programme unit.

Lectures

The Contemporary Art Practice Lecture series features presentations from leading practitioners in the field.

Seminars and Workshops
Contemporary Art Practice seminars are designed to inform your practice, encourage collaborations and to support and enhance your professional practical skills.

Individual Tutorials
One-to-one tutorials offer opportunities for formative feedback throughout the duration of your studies. You will have a personal tutor assigned to monitor your progress and offer support and you will also have the opportunity to sign up for one-to-one tutorials with visiting lecturers, artists, critics and curators.

Group Tutorials and Critiques
Group tutorials and critiques offer peer-to-peer and tutor feedback on your work in progress, also developing your skills in articulating critical feedback and demonstrating good practice in the ethical considerations of dialogue with others.

Presentations
Presentations throughout the degree are designed to develop skills in articulating and evaluating your work with feedback from tutors, peers and visiting lecturers.

Exhibitions and Events
Opportunities for making-public and experimenting with work-in-progress across a number of platforms are offered throughout the MA and in the final unit you will take part in a group exhibition.

Field Trips
Field trips include visits to galleries and scheduled talks with artists and curators. Where these are a core part of the teaching you will only pay for travel expenses. Any extra-curricular visits/trips are optional and will be at your own expense.

Self-Assessment
You will be supported in developing your skills in self-reflexivity throughout your studies, helping you to consider your own performance according to the programme learning outcomes and to develop your professional practice skills.

Presentation of Practice
The Presentation of Practice assessments take place during the final unit and allow for a platform to contextualise, evaluate and communicate your work presented for the Independent Research Project.

Technical and Studio Orientation and Inductions
IT, Library and Technical Services welcome inductions and studio orientations take place at the beginning of the academic year.

Technical Primers
A session into understanding the possibilities of a targeted range of technical capabilities as used in Art & Design.

Technical Workshops
Opportunities for self-selected technical workshops for support on specific projects or a self-selected masterclass focusing on a particular process or skill take place during units 1 and 2.

Negotiated Technical Learning
Appointments for one-to-one or small group instruction to support a specific piece of work are scheduled throughout each unit.

Your studies are divided into three terms and comprise scheduled staff-led time such as lectures, seminars and tutorials, as well as independent learning. Each term consists of 60 credits which equates to 600 study hours. During each week you should, as a full-time student, expect about 40 study hours. This is made up of two components:

- contact hours (approximately 5-10 per week) which involve timetabled interaction with tutors (for example, in seminars, critiques and tutorials), fostering intellectual exchange by way of clarifying concepts, addressing key questions and cultivating critical thinking;
- the time you dedicate to developing your work independently (in addition to the contact hours) by way of self-directed study which can include activities such as making in the workshops, working in the studio, conducting research or preparing for assessment.

The amount of time you spend in self-directed, independent study will normally increase as you progress to the final term, particularly as you focus on the public exhibition or completion of your work. The precise pattern of contact hours will vary by unit, term and mode of study.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations

The programme is subject to the Academic Regulations of the Royal College of Art (*the regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments*).

Unit Assessment

Situating Contemporary Art Practice
Formative assessment takes place in the form of 1:1 and peer-to-peer feedback throughout the programme series of personal tutorials, group seminars, workshops and critiques that support student development in unit 1. Students submit a Self-Assessment Report that contextualises their practice and evaluates progress and receive feedback on the report, along with performance indicators assessed according to the learning outcomes of the unit.

Demonstrating Contemporary Art Practice
Formative assessment takes place in the form of 1:1 and peer-to-peer feedback throughout the programme series of personal tutorials, group seminars, workshops and critiques that continue to support student development throughout unit 2. Summative assessment includes presentations of work with feedback from tutors, peers and leading professionals within the field of contemporary art practice.

Independent Research Project
Formative assessment during the IRP takes place in the form of 1:1 and peer-to-peer feedback delivered through individual and group tutorials. Summative assessment takes the form assessment of the work presented for the public exhibition and an accompanying viva voce examination. Students will present their work in the form of an oral presentation that is accompanied by a Portfolio of Research and Practice that contextualises, evaluates and effectively communicates the Independent Research Project.

Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the unit descriptors, available at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What Award Can I Get?

To be awarded an RCA MA degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units.

Exit awards: If you have gained at least 60 credits at Level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Certificate. If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7 of the FHEQ, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma.